

Role Guide 3: Contact Research Assistant

Step-by-step instructions for the Contact RA role in the ABF-FST Digital Respondent Portal.

STUDY	Developing and Validating the Agribusiness Bankability Framework for Food Systems Transformation through Novel Financing Models in Zimbabwe (ABF-FST)
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FOR	Research assistants who contact organisations and invite respondents
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VERSION	Version 1.5 · 20 September 2026

Screenshots in this document use **fictional demonstration data**. Organisation and person names, phone numbers and figures shown in them are not real study records.

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1. Your role at a glance

You are the study's voice to the organisations assigned to you. You find the right senior person, record their contact details, send their personal invitation, log every attempt, send the approved reminders, and arrange calls for respondents who want help.

You can

- See the Main-400 Register — only the cases assigned to you — and open their case pages.
- Add and edit respondents and contact details.
- Send, resend and revoke invitations.
- Log contact attempts and change a case's status where allowed.
- Send follow-up reminders and manage appointments for your cases.

You cannot

- See cases assigned to other RAs, dashboards, QA, KII, documents, costs or exports.
- Assign cases, verify in bulk, activate Reserves or record a withdrawal (tell the Field Coordinator).
- See an invitation link again after leaving the page.

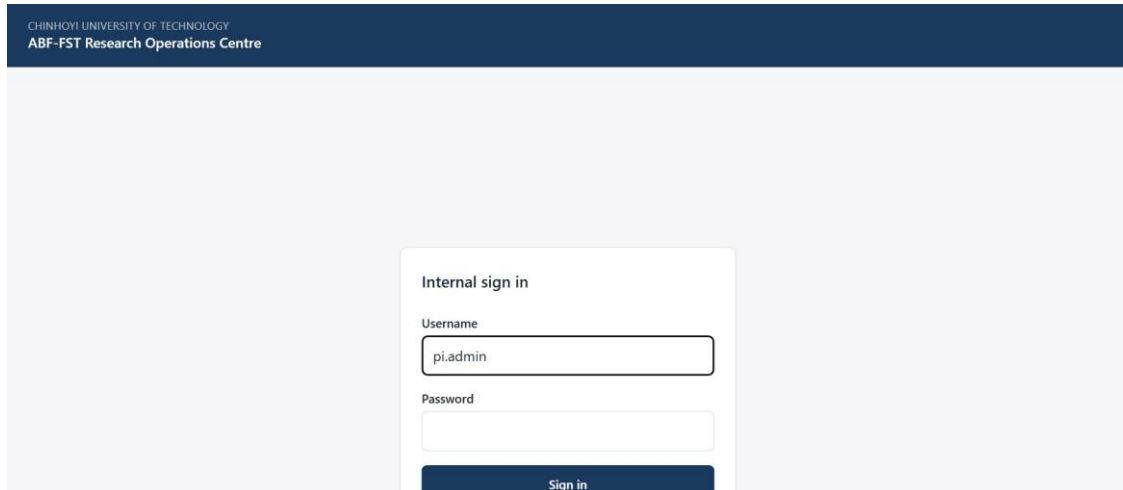
Where this fits

The System Manual explains how the whole system works. This guide covers only what you do. Ask the Field Coordinator or PI when something is outside your role.

2. Signing in and your screens

Signing in

1. Open <https://research.agribizframework.com/admin/login> in any modern browser (Chrome, Edge, Firefox or Safari), on a computer, tablet or phone.
2. Type your **Username** and **Password**, then select **Sign in**.



CHINHOMY UNIVERSITY OF TECHNOLOGY
ABF-FST Research Operations Centre

Internal sign in

Username
pi.admin

Password

Sign in

Figure 1. The sign-in screen for all internal staff.

3. You arrive on your start screen: **Main-400 Register**. The bar across the top lists only the screens your role (Contact RA) can open.

Accounts

There is no self-registration. The PI / System Admin creates every account and sets its role. Ask the PI if you need an account, a different role, or a password reset.

Finding your way around

- The **top bar** shows your username and role, and the screens you can use. It is not a full menu with some items greyed out: anything absent is simply not part of your role.
- Most screens have a **← Back to ...** link at the top that returns you to the screen you came from.
- Registers show **20 rows per page**. Use **Previous** and **Next** at the foot of the list, and the **Search** box above it.
- **Change password** (top right) lets you set a new password at any time. Choose a long password you do not use anywhere else.
- **Sign out** (top right) ends your session. Always sign out on a shared or public computer.
- If you are inactive for a while you may be asked to sign in again. This protects research data on unattended devices.



Figure 2. Opening a screen outside your role (for example from an old bookmark) shows this card instead of the screen.

Your screens

Screen	What you use it for
Main-400 Register	Your assigned cases; select View to work on one.
Appointments	Calls and sessions respondents have requested.
Follow-ups	Reminders due today for your cases.

Changing your password

1. Select **Change password** in the top right corner.
2. Enter your **Current password**, then the **New password** twice, and select **Change password**.

The screenshot shows the 'Change Password' screen. The top navigation bar includes 'Change password' and 'Sign out'. Below the navigation bar, there is a 'Back to Dashboard' link. The main content area has a heading 'Change Password' and three input fields: 'Current password', 'New password', and 'Confirm new password'. A 'Change password' button is located at the bottom of the form.

Figure 3. Change Password screen.

3. Use the new password next time you sign in. If you have forgotten your password, ask the PI to reset it.

3. Your routine

A suggested rhythm. Adjust it to the Field Coordinator's plan.

When	What to do
Start of day	Follow-ups: send every reminder due and mark each sent. Appointments: confirm today's.
Main work	Cases at S03: record the respondent and number, send invitations. Cases with no number: phone the organisation to identify the right person.
After every call or message	Log the contact attempt with outcome and a short note.
End of day	Anything unusual (refusal, withdrawal, wrong organisation) reported to the Field Coordinator.

4. Step-by-step tasks

4.1 Finding your cases

1. Select **Main-400 Register**. Only cases assigned to you are listed.

ABF-FST Research Operations Centre
contact.ra · Contact RA

Change password Sign out

Main-400 Register Appointments Follow-ups

Main-400 Register

Search ID or organisation Main

Sample ID	Master ID	Organisation	Status
SID-2026-000001	MID-HA-000001	Musasa Valley Growers Cooperative	S05 View
SID-2026-000003	MID-MK-000001	Baobab Ridge Grain Millers (Pvt) Ltd	S03 View
SID-2026-000005	MID-MA-000001	Mukwa Hills Agro-Dealers	S03 View
SID-2026-000007	MID-MI-000001	Nyati Plains Fresh Produce Market	S03 View
SID-2026-000009	MID-MV-000001	Mopane Springs Dairy Processors	S03 View
SID-2026-000011	MID-BU-000001	Kudu Crossing Poultry Farmers Association	S03 View
SID-2026-000013	MID-ME-000001	Mhondoro Heights Irrigation Services	S03 View
SID-2026-000015	MID-MC-000001	Sable Creek Rural Finance Trust	S03 View
SID-2026-000017	MID-MS-000001	Tamarind Flats Cotton Ginners	S03 View
SID-2026-000019	MID-MN-000001	Jacaranda Park Livestock Traders	S03 View
SID-2026-000021	MID-HA-000003	Ironwood Vale Growers Cooperative	S03 View
SID-2026-000023	MID-MK-000003	Marula Bend Grain Millers (Pvt) Ltd	S03 View
SID-2026-000025	MID-MA-000003	Granite Kopje Agro-Dealers	S05 View
SID-2026-000027	MID-MI-000003	Riverbend Fresh Produce Market	S05 View
SID-2026-000029	MID-MV-000003	Red Earth Dairy Processors	S05 View

Figure 4. Main-400 Register for a Contact RA.

2. Type a Sample ID, Master ID or organisation name in **Search**, or page through with **Next**.
3. Select **View** to open the case page.

4.2 Recording the respondent and their contact details

Invitations and reminders need a phone or WhatsApp number. Record the eligible person as soon as they are identified.

1. Open the case (**Main-400 Register → View**) and find **Respondents and contact details**.
2. Select **Add a person**. Enter **Full name**, **Phone**, **WhatsApp number**, **Email**, and a **Gatekeeper name** and **Gatekeeper contact** if you reach the person through a PA or receptionist.

Figure 5. Adding a person to a case.

- Choose their **role** and the eligibility decision: **Eligible (I screened them)**, **Not eligible**, or **Not yet screened**.
- Select **Save person**. To correct details later, select **Edit** beside the person, change the fields, then **Save changes**.
- Write WhatsApp numbers in international form, e.g. **+263 77 123 4567**, so the WhatsApp buttons open the right chat.

Who is eligible?

Owner or founder, CEO or managing director, finance/credit/risk, operations, strategy/business development, supply chain/commercial, or another senior manager who can answer for the organisation. Anyone else should nominate the right person.

4.3 Sending an invitation

- Open the case. Check the status is **S03** and a respondent with a number is recorded.
- In **Invitations**, leave **Channel** as **WHATSAPP** (or choose EMAIL, SMS, PRINTED_CODE or QR to record how it was delivered) and **Wave** as **1**. Select **Send invitation**.

Wave	Channel	Status	Issued	Actions
1	WHATSAPP	SENT	9/15/2026	Revoke

Figure 6. Invitations panel before sending, with the history of earlier invitations.

- The personal link and 8-character manual code appear **once**, with the invitation already written for each channel. Choose **WhatsApp message**, **SMS message** or **Email message** to see exactly what will be sent: the personal link, its expiry date, the manual code and the study contact line.

Invitations

Invitation link (shown once -- send it now)

`http://localhost:3000/1/WPIS_gIH6Wn3HQArJwKBDrd0xedUMjR-nUK2IRHHk`

Manual code (for phone-assisted administration): 34BOJDLN - expires 9/30/2026

WhatsApp message SMS message Email message

Hello. You are invited to take part in the ABF-FST research study at Chinhoyi University of Technology on agribusiness financing in Zimbabwe. Taking part is voluntary.

Your personal link: `http://localhost:3000/1/WPIS_gIH6Wn3HQArJwKBDrd0xedUMjR-nUK2IRHHk`
(valid until 30 September 2026)

Prefer to answer by phone? Reply to this message and quote code 34BOJDLN.

Questions: Happyson Saina, 0773943709, abffst.research.cut@gmail.com

Send via WhatsApp **Copy message**

Opens the chat with Tendai Demo-Moyo (+263770001000). Send it from the study WhatsApp number.
After sending, log it under Contact timeline.

Figure 7. The link, manual code and ready-written messages are shown once, with a send button for each channel.

4. Send it on the channel that suits the respondent:
 - **Send via WhatsApp** opens that respondent's chat (their WhatsApp number, or phone number if none) with the message ready. Check you are on the study WhatsApp number, then press Send.
 - **Send by SMS** opens the phone's messages app addressed to the respondent, with the shorter SMS message. Use it on a phone.
 - **Email from study address** sends the email from `abffst.research.cut@gmail.com` to the respondent's email on file; replies go to the study inbox. The email is recorded in the audit log.
 - **Open in email app** opens the same email in your own mail program, if you need to add something first.
 - **Copy message** copies the message shown, for any other channel.
5. If a button says no number or email is on file, add it under **Respondents and contact details**, then send a new invitation.
6. The case moves to **S05 Invitation sent** automatically. Log the attempt in **Contact timeline** (see Logging a contact attempt).

The link is shown only once

The portal stores only a scrambled fingerprint of the link, so nobody can display it again. If you close the page before sending, select **Send new invitation (replaces current)**: this issues a fresh link and the old one stops working immediately.

Links are valid for **14 days**. Each link belongs to one organisation; never forward one respondent's link to another organisation.

Revoking an invitation

In the invitation history, select **Revoke** on an open invitation (for example, if it was sent to the wrong number). The link stops working at once. Issue a new one if the case should still be invited.

4.4 Logging a contact attempt

Record **every** attempt, successful or not. The Contact Dashboard, Reports and any later replacement decision rely on it.

1. On the case page, scroll to **Contact timeline** → **Log a contact attempt**.

The figure shows a 'Contact timeline' section with the text 'No contact events recorded yet.' Below this is a 'Log a contact attempt' section. It contains two dropdown menus: 'PHONE' and 'REACHED'. Below these is a text input field labeled 'Notes (optional)'. At the bottom of this section is a blue button labeled 'Log contact attempt'.

Figure 8. Contact timeline and the form for logging an attempt.

2. Choose the **channel** (WHATSAPP, EMAIL, PHONE, SMS, FACE_TO_FACE) and the **outcome** (REACHED, NO_ANSWER, WRONG_NUMBER, REFUSED, RESCHEDULED, COMPLETED).
3. Add a short, factual note (optional), e.g. "PA says MD travelling; call back Thursday". Do not record opinions about the person.
4. Select **Log contact attempt**. The entry appears at the top of the timeline with the date and time.

4.5 Sending follow-up reminders

Approved reminders fall due on **Day 2** and **Day 7** after an invitation for respondents who have not yet submitted. Until automatic WhatsApp sending is connected, a person sends each one.

1. Select **Follow-ups**. Each card shows the case, organisation, which reminder is due, when the invitation went out, the respondent and their number, and the exact approved message.

The figure shows a screenshot of the 'Follow-ups' section in the ABF-FST Research Operations Centre. The header includes 'ABF-FST Research Operations Centre', 'contact.ra · Contact RA', and links for 'Change password' and 'Sign out'. Below the header is a navigation bar with 'Main-400 Register', 'Appointments', and 'Follow-ups'. A link '← Back to Main-400 Register' is visible. The main content area is titled 'Follow-ups due' and includes the instruction: 'Approved reminders for invited cases that haven't responded yet. Open WhatsApp, send the message, then mark it sent.' There are three cards, each representing a case. Each card shows a case ID (e.g., SID-2026-000039), the organisation name (e.g., Silver Stream Livestock Traders), and the reminder type (e.g., Day 7 final routine attempt). Each card contains a pre-filled WhatsApp message and two buttons: 'Open WhatsApp (choose contact)' and 'Mark as sent'.

Figure 9. Follow-ups due. Contact RAs see only their own cases.

2. Select **Open in WhatsApp**. WhatsApp opens with the message ready for that number; send it. If the card says **no number on file**, the button reads **Open WhatsApp (choose contact)** — pick the chat yourself, and add the number to the case afterwards.
3. Come back and select **Mark as sent**. The card disappears and the reminder is recorded under your name.

Mark as sent only after sending

A case can become **S13 Nonresponse** (and be replaced by its Reserve) only after every reminder has been recorded as sent. Marking a reminder you did not send could lead to an organisation being replaced without being contacted.

4.6 Managing appointments

1. Select **Appointments**. Each row shows the case (Sample ID and organisation) or KII, the requested time, the mode (PHONE, WHATSAPP_VOICE, ZOOM, ...) and the status.

Case / informant	Scheduled for	Mode	Status	Actions
SID-2026-000045 Highveld Meadow Agro-Dealers	9/13/2026, 7:15:00 PM	PHONE	COMPLETED	No further action
SID-2026-000051 Baobab Ridge Poultry Farmers Association	9/14/2026, 7:15:00 PM	FACE_TO_FACE	MISSED	No further action
SID-2026-000025 Granite Kopje Agro-Dealers	9/16/2026, 9:15:00 PM	PHONE	REQUESTED	CONFIRMED CANCELLED
SID-2026-000029 Red Earth Dairy Processors	9/18/2026, 12:15:00 AM	WHATSAPP_VOICE	CONFIRMED	COMPLETED MISSED CANCELLED
SID-2026-000087 Silver Stream Fresh Produce Market	9/18/2026, 10:00:00 AM	PHONE	REQUESTED	CONFIRMED CANCELLED
SID-2026-000041 Acacia Downs Growers Cooperative	9/18/2026, 7:15:00 PM	ZOOM	REQUESTED	CONFIRMED CANCELLED

Figure 10. Appointment Queue.

2. Use **Filter by status** to show, for example, only **REQUESTED** appointments.
3. Contact the respondent to confirm, then select **CONFIRMED**.
4. After the session select **COMPLETED**, or **MISSED** if they did not attend, or **CANCELLED**. Only valid next steps are shown; a finished appointment shows **No further action**.

4.7 Phone, WhatsApp-call or face-to-face administration

When the respondent prefers help, the researcher completes the questionnaire with them. The respondent must still hear the participant information and agree before any question is asked.

1. Agree a time. If the respondent booked through the portal, it is in **Appointments**.
2. At the start of the call, confirm the organisation and the person's role, read or summarise the Participant Information Sheet (v1.3) and ask for consent. Stop if they decline.
3. Open the respondent's personal invitation link on your device and go through the portal screens with them (organisation, role, information, consent), choosing the answers they give you.
4. Open the questionnaire from the portal so the case identifiers travel with the form, and complete it with the respondent. Never start the KoboToolbox form from a bookmark: a submission without the portal's link is set aside and not matched.
5. After submitting, log the contact attempt with outcome **COMPLETED**, and mark the appointment **COMPLETED**.

Code	Mode	What happens
01	Web self-administration	The respondent completes the questionnaire alone from the link.
02	WhatsApp link, self-completion	The link is sent by WhatsApp; the respondent completes it alone.
03	Telephone, interviewer-administered	A researcher calls and completes the form while the respondent answers.
04	WhatsApp call, interviewer-assisted	As 03, over a WhatsApp voice or video call.
05	Video call, interviewer-assisted	As 03, over Teams, Zoom or Google Meet.
06	Face to face	In person; the researcher operates the device.

4.8 When the person is not the right respondent

- If someone chooses **None of these describe me**, the portal thanks them and the questionnaire never opens. No answers are recorded.
- Ask them politely to nominate the right senior person, record that person under **Respondents and contact details**, and send a new invitation.
- If nobody suitable exists, record the reason in the contact timeline and move the case to **S14 Ineligible** (Field Coordinator or PI).

4.9 When someone refuses or asks to withdraw

1. Thank them politely and do not try to persuade them.
2. Log the contact attempt with outcome **REFUSED** and their words in the note.
3. Tell the Field Coordinator the same day. They record the withdrawal or refusal and decide on the Reserve.
4. Do not contact the person again.

4.10 What to say to a respondent

- Who you are: a research assistant on the ABF-FST study at Chinhoyi University of Technology, led by Happyson Saina.
- Why them: their organisation was selected to take part in a doctoral study on agribusiness financing readiness.
- What it involves: a questionnaire of about 15–25 minutes, online or with a researcher by phone or WhatsApp.
- It is voluntary and confidential; no score, rating or financing decision is produced, and answers are never shared with lenders.
- Questions: Happyson Saina, 0773943709, abffst.research.cut@gmail.com.

5. Rules you must follow

- Contact only the cases assigned to you.
- Never send one organisation's link to another, and never post links in groups.
- Mark a reminder as sent only after you have sent it.
- Treat everything in the portal as **confidential research data**. Do not screenshot, copy, print or forward names, phone numbers, email addresses or answers except as your role requires.
- Never share your username or password, and never sign in for someone else.
- Use the respondent's contact details **only** to manage their participation in this study (invitations, reminders, appointments).
- Never tell a respondent, lender or anyone else that answers affect financing. The study generates **no score, rating or financing decision**.
- If a respondent asks to withdraw, stop contacting them and tell the Field Coordinator or PI the same day so the withdrawal is recorded.
- Report a lost device, a suspected account compromise, or data sent to the wrong person to the PI immediately.

6. Troubleshooting

Situation	Likely cause	What to do
The case is not in my register	It is assigned to someone else or unassigned.	Ask the Field Coordinator to assign it.
No Send invitation button	Your role is read-only here, or the case is a locked Reserve.	Check with the Field Coordinator.
WhatsApp opens the wrong chat	The number is missing the country code.	Edit the person: +263 followed by the number without the first 0.
I closed the page before copying the link	Links are shown once.	Select Send new invitation (replaces current).
"This screen isn't part of your role"	The screen belongs to another role (often an old bookmark or shared link).	Select Go to my start screen. If you need that screen, ask the PI about your role.
"Too many sign-in attempts from this network"	Sign-in is rate-limited per network; an office shares one address.	Wait a minute and try again. A wrong password says so explicitly.
A register shows fewer rows than expected	Registers show 20 rows per page; a Contact RA sees only assigned cases.	Use Next, or search. Ask the Field Coordinator to assign the case.
A button is greyed out	A required step is missing (a note, an authenticity decision, a selection).	Read the message beside the button; complete the missing step first.
"KoboToolbox couldn't be reached"	KoboToolbox is slow or the connection token has changed.	Try again in a few minutes. If it persists, tell the PI.
Form PDFs says "Not in sync with KoboToolbox yet"	The counts differ: a form was submitted or changed in KoboToolbox since the last sync (it runs every 15 minutes).	Select Sync now. If it still differs, or says it couldn't reach KoboToolbox, try again in a few minutes and tell the PI if it persists.
A document says "Already submitted" and its answers are locked	Its coding was already sent to KoboToolbox; changing it here would not change that record.	To redo the coding, delete that record in KoboToolbox, then select Sync now on Form PDFs. The document unlocks.
A page keeps loading	A slow or dropped connection.	Refresh the page. Your saved work is not lost; unsaved typing may be.
A file upload seems stuck	A large file on a slow connection takes time; the bar shows how much has been sent.	Wait for Saving... and the file name. If it fails, try again or upload a smaller version.

7. Quick reference

Sign in	https://research.agribizframework.com/admin/login
You start on	Main-400 Register
Invitation valid	14 days
Reminders	Day 2 and Day 7, from Follow-ups
Outcome codes	REACHED, NO_ANSWER, WRONG_NUMBER, REFUSED, RESCHEDULED, COMPLETED
Help	Field Coordinator; PI: Happyson Saina, 0773943709, abffst.research.cut@gmail.com